

■ Fresh Start Effect

■ What is it?

Special moments give people extra motivation.

The Fresh Start Effect is the boost in energy and motivation people feel when starting something new.

For example, think of the excitement around **New Year's resolutions**—a natural time to set goals and commit to change.

■■ History

The Fresh Start Effect was studied by **Katherine Milkman and colleagues (2014)**, who showed that “**temporal landmarks**”—like a new week, a birthday, or New Year's Day—make people feel like they're starting fresh.

This mindset helps people separate their “past self” from their “new self,” creating motivation for change.

■ The Psychology Behind It

- People use **temporal landmarks** (new year, new week, birthdays, etc.) as mental resets.
- These moments boost optimism and encourage **goal-setting**.
- The brain sees it as an opportunity to “start over,” re-energizing focus and effort.

■■ Why It Matters

The Fresh Start Effect can:

- Boost sales around seasonal events
- Provide strong entry points for habit formation
- Bring inactive users back to a product
- Increase willingness to commit to new goals
- Open time-sensitive opportunities for businesses

■ How to Apply It

- **Time campaigns wisely** → e.g., New Year fitness ads, back-to-school promotions.
- **Use product launches** → tie new releases to seasonal fresh starts.
- **Encourage habit resets** → challenges, streaks, or goal trackers.
- **Rebrand or refresh** → position updates as a “new beginning.”
- **Celebrate progress** → reward milestones to keep motivation alive.

■ Theory in Action

- **Fitness apps** run summer or New Year challenges to tap into users’ motivation for a reset.
- **Apple** launches new products in September, aligning with fall resets and the holiday season.

■ Final Thought

Fresh starts are powerful triggers, but the challenge isn’t just getting people excited at the beginning.

The real win is **sustaining motivation**—helping users keep going long after the “new beginning” buzz fades.